

ALIENATION, SELF ASSERTION AND IMMIGRANT SENSIBILITY IN BHARATI MUKHERJEE'S '*WIFE AND JASMINE*'

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ABSTRACT

The Indian born writer Bharati Mukherjee is one of the most broadly known immigrant writers of America. Bharati Mukherjee contemplates herself different from other European Writers for a variety of reasons. Dimple and Jasmine, the female protagonists of Bharati Mukherjee's **Wife and Jasmine**, face the problem of loss of culture and the quest for a new identity in the US. Do they too find the loss of old culture an exhilarating experience? Are they thrilled at the prospect of giving up their old identity and assuming a new one? Does the society which is free from the shackles of caste, gender and family offer them the desired freedom? The present paper will discuss Bharati Mukherjee's *Wife and Jasmine* with these questions in mind. Besides being provided ample discussions on the above questions the paper also focuses on how these women suffer alienation and finally assert their individuality in the context of immigrant sensibility in course of time.

KEYWORDS: Loss of Friendly Culture, Loss of Supportive Community, Feeling of Alienation and Immigrant Sensibility

INTRODUCTION

Bharati Mukherjee is an award-winning [Indian-born American writer](#). She was born on 27 July 1940 in Calcutta of [Bengali](#) origin to Bengali Brahmins, members of the highest caste among Bengali Hindus, Sudhir Mukherjee and Bina Mukherjee. Sudhir Lal Mukherjee, was a chemist and her mother, though not very educated, ensured that all their three daughters received the best of education. In Calcutta, Bharati Mukherjee grew up in a middle-class joint family at Rash Behari Avenue. In Indian culture and Hindu family and especially in a joint family where everyone is concerned about the other person. Everyone tends to butt-in, in the affairs of others and the name given to it is 'concern' and 'love'

The immigrant writers in America can be divided into two categories. Firstly, the 'Willing Immigrant-Writers' who settled in America from Europe and Asia and who have made it their home. The Second category consists of the 'Unwilling Immigrant-Writers' with African origin whose grandparents were brought to America in some slave trip.

The immigrants in an alien lands are often recognized in great dismay, the loneliness of their condition. The uncertain hazards of new lands are exposed them to perilous risks. In such a helpless condition, they needed to befriend , for unaided, they knew they were doomed. These situations occur in the Bharati Mukherjee's novels '*Wife and Jasmine*'

While going through the novel **Wife**, a question always recurs: if some personal experience was involved while narrating the character of Dimple Dasgupta, a girl from middle class, Bengali Brahmin family whose idea of marriage is of 'freedom'. It always occurred, why a middle-class girl? A girl from any class faces the same situation with little variation in some cases in the Indian orthodox society. A society where girl fetus is killed, Dimple skips her way to freedom by aborting her child. Bharati Mukherjee has chosen a protagonist from the middle class who is ambitious but is also neurotic. The aim in her life is to get married to a man who will give her freedom. But still her ideals are "Sita" and "Savitri".

Jasmine forms the focal point of transformation and evolving of Bharati Mukherjee's protagonists. The transformation of Jasmine in the New World, marked with her being raped by Half-Face, and Jasmine avenging herself, depicts in a way her avenging the innocent death of her husband by killing Half-Face.

Bharati Mukherjee's '**Wife**' and '**Jasmine**' are chronicling the journeys of two young women to the US for different reasons, under dissimilar circumstances. Both of them pass through torturous physical, mental and emotional agony affecting their whole being to such an extent that they are driven to violence. Jasmine starts her life in the US with a murder. Dimple rounds up her stay there with a murder.

Dimple Dasgupta, the protagonist of the novel, *Wife*, (1975) it is constant fight within the- bonded and enchained Dimple who wants freedom and love. Brought up in an upper middle class conservative environment, she leads a protected life throughout and as expected from a girl of Hindu traditional family is shy, docile and submissive, is married to Amit Basu, an ambitious engineer. It is an arranged marriage and takes place about to migrate to the US. She thought of pre-marital "life as a dress rehearsal for actual living."

Delay in marriage makes her very nervous and anxious. She does not like the new name Nandini has given to her by her mother-in-law and she also finds the apartment is very small and unattractive. She is only on a phone's distance from her mother and her friend Pixie who helps in subsiding the rebellion brewing up in her. Moreover the talk of immigration makes her sanguine. Her unconventional mode of thinking can be perceived in her unusual reaction to her pregnancy "she turns towards motherhood with an overpowering zest..... as she lacks companionship, her husband having found no time for her turns towards her children for companionship and emotional fulfillment."

In the US Dimple is left alone with Amit, back home she has held him in high esteem. The commendable comments and remarks of her friends and mother has drawn her attention to her husband's virtues and qualities but in US everything turns against him. Lack of a job makes him less self-assure and more self-centre. His own problems partly turn him apathetic towards Dimple's piling mental and emotional turmoil while Amit goes on searching for a job, Dimple is planning to buy a queen size bed.

She prepares salad with great care and effort; Amit refuses even to taste it. When Dimple offers to fix the tie for him as a goodwill gesture, Amit turns down the offer of help. Amit fails Dimple on all planes-physical, mental and emotional. She turns towards Ina, Leni and ultimately Milt Glasser in her moments of crises. Ina and Leni fail as her friends. Milt proves to be a temporary transgression.

"The rebel in her is devising new means and ways to commit suicide. She is alienated being undergoing the supposed after effects of alienation-psychosis, psychosomatic disorder, delinquency and contemplation of suicide". Torn by her psychic and emotional tensions, she takes the drastic step of murdering her husband, thinking that she cannot bear this sort of life forever. In a stunningly calm manner she takes out the knife from the kitchen drawer and dives it down on a spot near his hairline repeatedly hitting at the same place seven times. Thus she punishes her inattentive husband for his lapses and unceremoniously ends up her disharmonious marital life.

Dimple and Jasmine are antithetical to each other. Jasmine takes over from Dimple. Like Dimple, Jasmine too is a rebel for quite different reasons. Her husband Prakash is senselessly shot of death in a Jullundhur shoe-shop by the Khalsa lions. Jyothi, benumbed with grief, resolves to complete Prakash's mission and thus averages his death. On her very first day in the US, she does her rapist Half-face to death with a knife. Unlike Dimple, Jasmine starts off her life in the US with a murder. Dimple has an uncaring husband, so she butchers him. Jasmine has a faithful and loving husband who is mercilessly butchered by the terrorists, so she pledges to avenge his death.

In **'Wife'** Bharati Mukherjee had portrayed the hollowness of the Indian institutionalized marriage. In *Jasmine* she is highlighting the impossibility of nuptial longevity in a country that thrives on change. In the US the Indian concept of formalized relationships and institutionalized togetherness holds no water. Back home in India, Bharathi Mukherjee, the middle of three daughters, have seen a stereotypical pattern of a conventional Indian marriage and preferred the new world of Iowa. *Jasmine* too is excited by the new world.

It is the sight of Prakash's killer in Central Park that forces *Jasmine* to run away from New York to Iowa. She is running away for life, not escaping from life which is again a positive step. Dimple was obsessed with death, devising in her mind new ways of committing suicide. *Jasmine* too thinks of suicide for a brief moment after her rape. "It was the murkiness of mirror and sudden sense of mission that stopped me. What if my mission was not yet over?"⁴

In Iowa she achieves a new identity as Jane Ripplemeyer with Bud, a fifty-year old agro-banker and their adopted son Du, a young Vietnamese Orphan. Bud deeply in love with Jane, proposes to her but Jane, carrying his child, is in no hurry to grab this proposal of marriage. *Jasmine* is vital to Bud, Taylor, Duff and Du.

They all love her and depend on her. She learns how to reinvent both herself and the American dream. She finds a permanent home for herself with Taylor and Duff in California. Dimple's feeling of guilt is transplanted by the feeling of relief in *Jasmine*. "It isn't guilt that I feel, it isn't relief".

For Dimple the loss of the old culture is neither an exciting nor exhilarating experience. She is disillusioned on all planes-physical, mental and emotional. On killing of her husband is partly an act of desperation and partly an outcome of her guilty conscience. She is uneasy about her extramarital relationship with Milt Glasser. Unable to cope with the crisis, she kills her husband. *Jasmine*, on the contrary, has broken away from the shackles of castes, gender and family. The very essence of *Jasmine* resides in the concept of endless possibility.

She proves by her grit and determination that change and adaptability are key to survival, and that a successful immigrant requires instinct. In the end, she decides to leave Bud and move to California with Taylor, grasping at yet another chance at happiness.

By doing so, she is not merely choosing between Bud and Taylor, she symbolically asserts her right to try and move her stars, instead of passively accepting her fate. She has learnt by now that nothing lasts forever and so she needs not condemn herself to a life she does not want. Self-assertion is a power that she believes in, and is beginning to enjoy. She has learnt to live not for her husband or for her children but for herself.

CONCLUSIONS

As an immigrant writer Bharati Mukherjee in her novels made a concerted effort to conceptualize the image of the immigrants, who assert their claim to an American identity by struggling heroically to reinstate themselves successfully in a new cultural landscape.

Wife brings a unique Indian perspective to the standard themes of immigrant fiction- failed quests, thwarted dreams, dislocation and isolation leading to marital stress, demand of a new and hostile cultural environment, loss of a supportive community and loss of a relatively coherent earlier identity. In the novel *Jasmine* resides in the concept of endless possibility.

Within the few years of the life of *Jasmine* –the young Indian protagonist from Punjab- a lifetime of experiences is stored. How she proved by her grit and determination that change and adaptability are key to survival, and that a successful immigrant requires instinct.



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